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Climate Creators to Watch: Changing the Narrative Online

Abstract

Young people increasingly learn about climate change on social media, where misinformation and doom-and-gloom messages spread easily. Harvard Chan C-CHANGE and the climate media company Pique Action curate an annual list of Climate Creators to Watch: scientists, educators, and activists whose educational and entertaining content counters misinformation and helps people focus on solutions.

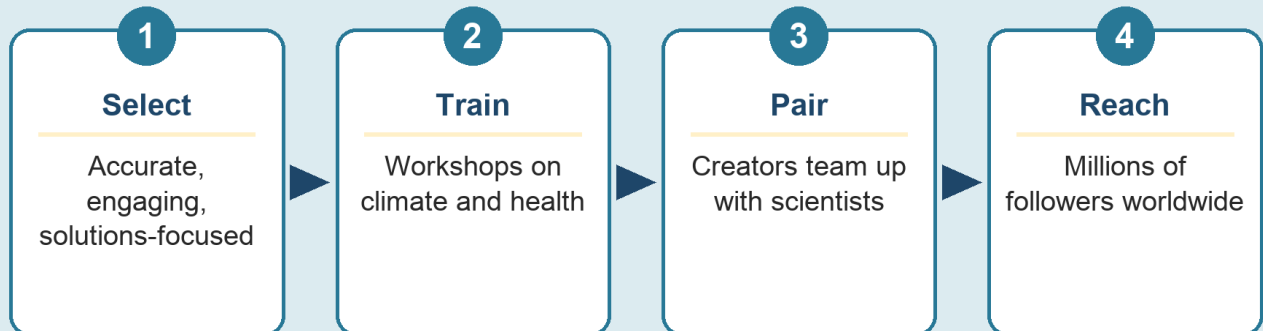
Introduction

Scroll through any social media feed and you may find climate content that is false, confusing, or so hopeless that it makes people want to give up. Harvard Chan C-CHANGE wanted to change that narrative. Rather than only publishing research papers, the center teamed up with Pique Action to spotlight creators who are already reaching millions of people on platforms like YouTube, Instagram, TikTok, and X. Their content is chosen for being both educational and entertaining, and for empowering people to focus on solutions that improve their health and the health of the planet. The project treats social media creators as important partners in climate communication.

How Do Scientists Study This?

Each year, C-CHANGE and Pique Action review creators producing solutions-focused climate content and select a list of Climate Creators to Watch. Selection looks for scientifically backed content that is educational and entertaining, counters misinformation, and offers an antidote to doom-and-gloom messaging. Selected creators attend training workshops, speak at programs such as the C-CHANGE Youth Summit, and are paired with climate scientists so they can share new and ongoing Harvard research with their audiences. C-CHANGE also shares tips for science communication on TikTok, helping scientists and creators learn from one another about what makes content engaging and trustworthy.

How the Creators list works



Find creators

Review creators whose climate content is accurate, engaging, and focused on solutions.

Connect with science

Pair creators with Harvard scientists and offer training workshops.

Amplify

Share the list and creators' work to reach young audiences worldwide.

What Did They Discover?

By 2024, the list was in its third year and named 17 social media creators who collectively reach over 4 million followers. That year's list had a bigger international focus, with creators from countries including Ecuador, the United Kingdom, India, and Zambia, covering topics such as climate racism, Indigenous culture, sustainable fashion, and wildlife photography. One creator, atmospheric physicist Simon Clark, said his goal is to improve people's climate literacy and to humanize scientists, eroding the us-and-them divide. He called the list proof that climate communication is evolving and maturing. Program director Skye Flanigan said the list helps bridge the gap between climate scientists and young audiences.

Climate Creators to Watch

17

creators named to the 2024 list

4M+

followers reached by the 2024 creators

3rd

annual list in 2024, with a wider global focus

Flanigan noted that science communication does not end when a research paper is published; reaching people where they are is part of the work.

Takeaways

Meet people online

Young people turn to social media, so accurate climate content must be there too.

Solutions over doom

Hopeful, action-focused content helps people stay engaged instead of giving up.

Scientists plus creators

Partnerships make research accessible, entertaining, and trustworthy.

Key Terms

Science communication (SciComm)

Sharing scientific knowledge with the public in clear, engaging, and accurate ways.

Content creator

A person who produces videos, posts, or other media for an online audience.

Doom and gloom

Messaging that focuses only on disaster and hopelessness, which can discourage action.

Climate literacy

Understanding how the climate system works, how it is changing, and how to evaluate claims about it.

Misinformation

False or inaccurate information spread regardless of intent.

Words to Know · Climate Creators to Watch

Science communication (SciComm)

Content creator

Doom and gloom

Climate literacy

Misinformation

Activity

Create a 60-Second Climate Explainer

Students script and storyboard a short, accurate, solutions-focused climate video for social media.

Materials: Storyboard template with six frames; A reliable climate fact chosen from another IRISTEM lesson; Devices for recording (optional)

1. Pick one climate fact and one solution related to it.
2. Write a hook for the first three seconds that grabs attention without exaggerating.
3. Storyboard six frames: hook, fact, why it matters, solution, what viewers can do, and your source.
4. Swap storyboards with a partner and check: is it accurate, engaging, and hopeful?
5. Revise and, if possible, record your explainer to share with the class.

References

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